Giant Pharaoh Head Found in Egyptian Yard

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What would you do if you found a carved stone in your front yard? A homeowner in Egypt called the local authorities, and that choice led to an amazing discovery.

The man was working in front of his house in Behebat al-Hijara, a village in Egypt's Nile Delta, when he found a block of pink **granite** covered in **hieroglyphics**. **Archaeologists** came to finish the dig. Within a few feet of the block, they uncovered a five-foot-tall stone head of **Pharaoh** Ramesses II, one of the longest-ruling kings in Egyptian history. He reigned from about 1279 to 1213 B.C.E.

The head is well preserved, though the statue's body and base are still missing. It shows the king wearing a double crown, a symbol that he ruled both Upper and Lower Egypt. Writing on the statue's back pillar gives one of his official names, which roughly means "The Strong Bull, Beloved of Truth." Based on the head's size, experts think the full statue once stood about 28 feet tall.

The team also found the upper part of a second statue, about eight feet long. Its face looks similar, and it wears a striped royal headdress called a **nemes**. Because pieces are missing, experts cannot yet say for sure that it shows Ramesses II.

The **granite** block also carries two of the king's titles. Together, the three finds have officials from Egypt's Ministry of Tourism and **Antiquities** wondering whether a lost temple to Ramesses II lies nearby. Another possibility is that the pieces were moved there from somewhere else. **Archaeologists** plan to keep digging to find out.

Word Treasure

hieroglyphics -- Hieroglyphics are the picture symbols ancient Egyptians used for writing.

Archaeologists -- Archaeologists are scientists who study past human life by digging up and examining objects people left behind.

Pharaoh -- A pharaoh was a king of ancient Egypt.

granite -- Granite is a very hard rock often used for statues and buildings.

nemes -- A nemes is the striped cloth headdress worn by ancient Egyptian kings.

Antiquities -- Antiquities are objects, buildings or artworks from ancient times.

Background you need

Ancient Egyptian kings, called pharaohs, built huge statues and temples to show their power and honor the gods.

Ramesses II was one of the longest-ruling pharaohs, and statues of him have been found across Egypt.

The Nile Delta is the area in northern Egypt where the Nile River spreads out before reaching the Mediterranean Sea, and many ancient towns lie buried there.

In Egypt, people who find ancient objects are expected to report them so officials and archaeologists can study and protect them.

Break it down

LEAD: A homeowner in Egypt reports a carved stone, leading to a major discovery
KEY EVENT: Archaeologists uncover a five-foot head of Pharaoh Ramesses II
+- WHERE: Behebat al-Hijara, a village in the Nile Delta
+- WHEN: Ramesses II reigned from about 1279 to 1213 B.C.E.
DETAILS: Double crown, an inscribed Horus name, and a full statue once about 28 feet tall
SECOND FIND: Upper part of another statue wearing a nemes, possibly Ramesses II
EVIDENCE: Granite block carries two of the king's titles
OPEN QUESTION: Was there a lost temple here, or were the pieces moved? Digging continues

Why it matters

The finds could reveal a lost temple to one of Egypt's most powerful kings and show how reporting a discovery helps protect shared history.

Test what you remember

1. What did the homeowner first find?

(A) A clay pot
(B) A mummy
(C) A block of pink granite with hieroglyphics
(D) A gold mask

2. Which pharaoh does the large head show?

(A) Tutankhamun
(B) Khufu
(C) Cleopatra
(D) Ramesses II

3. How tall is the stone head?

(A) 28 feet
(B) Two feet
(C) Ten feet
(D) Five feet

4. How tall do experts think the full statue once stood?

(A) About 15 feet
(B) About 50 feet
(C) About 28 feet
(D) About 8 feet

5. What does the double crown symbolize?

(A) The king's wedding
(B) A religious holiday
(C) Rule over both Upper and Lower Egypt
(D) Victory in war

6. Why are experts not sure the second statue shows Ramesses II?

(A) Pieces of it are missing
(B) It was found in another country
(C) It has a different name carved on it
(D) It is made of wood

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: D 4: C 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Egypt's Ministry of Tourism and Antiquities: Officials wonder whether the finds point to an ancient temple dedicated to Ramesses II.

2. Archaeologists: Consider that the three pieces may instead have been moved to the site from elsewhere and plan more excavations.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):